

Activity 04: EtherChannel and STP resilience

TGS-2023037854 | v7.0 | 13 September 2026 | 100 minutes

Goal

Check LACP negotiation and spanning-tree redundancy without confusing blocked paths with failed links.

Before you start

Python 3.9+, a plain text editor and this complete folder. Offline mode requires no extra packages, Internet or credentials. The compulsory core Packet Tracer construction is specified below and in topology.md; advanced extensions may need CML/IOS XE.

Evidence boundary

All JSON/CSV observations are synthetic training evidence. Passing the Python checker validates the fixture contracts only. No hardware, simulator, authentication server or API is configured or contacted.

Files

README.md, instructions.pdf, checklist.pdf, topology.md, case.json, faulty.json, reference.json, observations.csv, specimen.cfg, S1-baseline.cfg, S2-baseline.cfg

Working method

case.json is the working evidence; faulty.json resets the exercise and reference.json shows corrected synthetic evidence for self-study. Preserve your own sandbox observations separately.

Detailed step-by-step instructions

1. Construct and save the mandatory simulator topology

Start Cisco Packet Tracer 8.x or a current compatible version. File > New; use the bottom device palette, drag these models into the workspace and rename them via Config > Display Name: 2 x Switch 2960 (S1,S2), 2 x PC-PT (PC1,PC2). Choose Connections > Copper Straight-Through for the table unless otherwise stated. Switch-to-switch links use Copper Cross-Over or Automatically Choose Connection Type. Click the first device and select its named interface; click the peer and select its named interface. Wait for links to initialize. Save as activity-start.pkt.

Device/port A	Device/port B	Cable
PC1 FastEthernet0	S1 FastEthernet0/1	Straight-through
PC2 FastEthernet0	S2 FastEthernet0/1	Straight-through
S1 FastEthernet0/23	S2 FastEthernet0/23	Cross-over/Auto
S1 FastEthernet0/24	S2 FastEthernet0/24	Cross-over/Auto
S1 GigabitEthernet0/1	S2 GigabitEthernet0/1	Cross-over/Auto

Save both activity-start.pkt and a working activity-working.pkt; use File > Save As.

2. Assign endpoint addresses and inspect interface identifiers

Set Desktop > IP Configuration > Static on each endpoint.

Endpoint	Address	Mask	Gateway	DNS
PC1	10.10.10.10	255.255.255.0	none	none
PC2	10.10.10.20	255.255.255.0	none	none

For routers/switches open CLI. Answer no to the initial configuration dialog and press Enter. Use the exact interface names below; a 2911 uses GigabitEthernet0/0 through 0/2, a 2960/3560 uses FastEthernet0/1 through 0/24 and GigabitEthernet0/1 through 0/2.

```
enable
show ip interface brief
```

3. Install all peer baseline configurations

Paste the complete corrected per-device blocks below, including the Po1 STP cost3 to prefer the channel over Gi0/1.

Device S1

```
enable
configure terminal
hostname S1
no ip domain-lookup
vlan 10
spanning-tree mode rapid-pvst
spanning-tree vlan 10 priority 4096
interface FastEthernet0/1
  switchport mode access
  switchport access vlan 10
  spanning-tree portfast
  no shutdown
exit
interface range FastEthernet0/23-24
  switchport mode trunk
```

```

switchport trunk allowed vlan 10
channel-group 1 mode active
no shutdown
exit
interface Port-channel1
spanning-tree vlan 10 cost 3
switchport mode trunk
switchport trunk allowed vlan 10
exit
interface GigabitEthernet0/1
switchport mode trunk
switchport trunk allowed vlan 10
no shutdown
exit
end
copy running-config startup-config

```

Device S2

```

enable
configure terminal
hostname S2
no ip domain-lookup
vlan 10
spanning-tree mode rapid-pvst
spanning-tree vlan 10 priority 8192
interface FastEthernet0/1
switchport mode access
switchport access vlan 10
spanning-tree portfast
no shutdown
exit
interface range FastEthernet0/23-24
switchport mode trunk
switchport trunk allowed vlan 10
channel-group 1 mode passive
no shutdown
exit
interface Port-channel1
spanning-tree vlan 10 cost 3
switchport mode trunk
switchport trunk allowed vlan 10
exit
interface GigabitEthernet0/1
switchport mode trunk
switchport trunk allowed vlan 10
no shutdown
exit
end
copy running-config startup-config

show running-config
show ip interface brief
copy running-config startup-config

```

4. Prove the healthy baseline with actual packets

Run every test below before introducing the fault. PC/Desktop > Command Prompt provides ping, ipconfig and arp. Use Simulation mode and Edit Filters to keep ARP, ICMP and the protocol under study; click Add Simple PDU for a ping and Capture/Forward to inspect hops. The first ping may lose one packet during ARP; repeat and record the second result. Do not mark a test passed until observed.

S1/S2 show etherchannel summary: Po1(SU), both Fa0/23 and Fa0/24 show (P). show spanning-tree vlan 10: S1 is root. The configured Po1 STP cost3 is lower than Gi0/1 cost4. Therefore S2 Po1 root forwarding, Gi0/1 alternate. PC1 ping PC2 succeeds. After Po1 shutdown Gi0/1 becomes forwarding. Measure actual simulated interruption; offline 2.1s is a synthetic example, not your measured result.

After all healthy tests pass, File > Save As > activity-start.pkt to preserve the CONFIGURED healthy baseline, then File > Save As > activity-working.pkt before introducing the fault. The initial empty construction is not the rollback baseline.

Save baseline screenshots / CLI text with device names; File > Save.

5. Introduce and diagnose the controlled fault

Save the baseline first. Apply only the following fault to the specified device. Repeat the same traffic tests, capture the first failing hop/control and compare show output with the healthy baseline.

After capturing baseline, shut S1 Port-channel1:

```
enable
configure terminal
interface Port-channel1
  shutdown
end
```

Repeat ping while RSTP reconverges; inspect the Gi0/1 alternate becoming forwarding. Restore Port-channel1 before the next fault. For LACP initiation failure, remove channel-group 1 from S1 Fa0/23-24 and recreate it mode passive; with S2 passive, no bundled LACP channel should form.

Retain activity-start.pkt and baseline running configurations; work in activity-working.pkt.

6. Apply the narrow repair and re-test the network

S1: configure terminal; interface Port-channel1; no shutdown; exit; interface range FastEthernet0/23-24; no channel-group 1; channel-group 1 mode active; end. If old membership exists remove it before changing mode. Keep S2 passive.

Repeat the baseline test matrix. Check surrounding controls as well as the repaired flow. why LACP needs at least one active peer and STP treats a correctly bundled channel as one logical link

Save actual show output and allowed/denied traffic results; copy running-config startup-config only after successful verification.

7. Rollback and rehearse recovery

Save the repaired file as activity-verified.pkt. To undo the exercise, open the saved healthy baseline activity-start.pkt after you have saved configurations into it at Step 3, or paste the saved pre-fault running configuration into a clean topology. For the specific repair, retain the exact old command/value rather than guessing a trunk list or ACL. Repeat one positive and one relevant negative test after recovery.

File > Save As > activity-verified.pkt; close working topology; reopen saved healthy baseline.

8. Submit observed evidence and explain the forwarding mechanism

Submit the verified .pkt file, a cabling/address table, pre-fault and post-repair show outputs, screenshots of traffic tests, diagnosis and rollback notes. Explain why LACP needs at least one active peer and STP treats a correctly bundled channel as one logical link Keep synthetic checker output separate from real simulator observations.

Record simulator version, device models and tests actually completed.

Untimed appendix: independent fixture analysis

These synthetic cases supplement the allocated hands-on time and do not configure the simulator.

Appendix 1. Establish the baseline

Open activity04-etherchannel-stp-resilience; inspect topology.md, case.json and observations.csv. Identify the controls for: Check LACP negotiation and spanning-tree redundancy without confusing blocked paths with failed links.

```
python3 --version
```

Appendix 2. Run the faulty evidence case

Run the checker against case.json; exit status 1 is expected at this stage. Record each FAIL label and the calculated detail.

```
python3 checker.py case.json
```

Appendix 3. Propose the repair

Use active/passive or active/active LACP. Set both members to speed 1000 and VLAN signature 10,20,99; set bundled true only for the corrected synthetic evidence. Explain why passive/passive never initiates negotiation. Open case.json in a plain text editor; preserve JSON types.

Appendix 4. Validate the corrected case

Save a separate working copy first. Run the checker after each narrow edit until all controls PASS; capture output as evidence. This validates fixtures only.

```
python3 checker.py case.json > evidence.txt
```

Appendix 5. Verify checker behavior

Run self-test; it must accept corrected reference evidence and reject the faulty fixture and the independent corrupted-control test.

```
python3 checker.py --self-test
```

Expected results and evidence

Corrected reference: all checks PASS, exit 0; faulty fixture: one or more FAIL, exit 1; self-test: PASS, exit 0. Domain-specific computed fields appear in JSON detail.

Capture evidence.txt, corrected case.json and your diagnosis. For sandbox work record device/model, timestamps, actual show outputs, allowed/denied tests and rollback. Distinguish fixture results from real observations.

Troubleshooting and reset

Exit 1: inspect the named failed contract. Exit 2: restore valid JSON keys/types. Unsupported simulator commands must be documented; never invent results. Reset by copying faulty.json over case.json. Restore sandbox settings from the actual saved baseline.

Calculated corrected-fixture results

```
calculated_root: "DIST1"  
convergence_seconds: 2.1
```

Required PASS controls

- LACP initiation
- channel member consistency
- intended STP root
- one redundant alternate
- alternate takes over within budget

Configuration files

The complete per-device configurations are shown in the construction steps and included as named *-baseline.cfg files. specimen.cfg combines those same blocks with explicit device boundaries. Apply each block only to its named device. WRT300N uses GUI settings instead of IOS CLI.

References

Cisco CCNA v1.1 exam topics; Cisco IOS XE configuration guides; Python ipaddress documentation. Exact URLs and source links are in README.md.